year by year. To list them in this fashion will mean, furthermore, that I won't have to deal with each of them separately as they came up, if there is no real significance in doing so. For 1950, then, we have:

1. Pebble in the Sky (Doubleday)

2. I, Robot (Gnome)

Financially, 1950 was an utter surprise. There was no way I would have predicted it, but everything seemed to move in my favor. The stories I wrote were longer and were sold for higher rates. When Horace took The Stars, like Dust— for serialization, that alone brought in nearly as much money as I had made in all of 1949. Add to that the advance from Doubleday on that same book, and the royalties they paid me on Pebble in the Sky. There were other sales at rates of up to $.03 a word, and apparently an ever-increasing market in anthologizations. By mid-July of 1950, I had matched my 1949 record, and by the end of the year, my earnings had just topped the $4,700 mark.

It was nearly three times the previous record of 1949, over half of what I made in all the years of writing before 1950, more than I made as an annual income from Elderfield, and almost as much as the $5,000 stipend I earned at Boston University. And all this from a spare-time activity.

For the first time, the thought flickered across my mind that I might conceivably make a living as a writer if I chose to.

In a way it was exceedingly fortunate that this had happened when it did and not two years sooner. Had I reason to think the thought at the end of 1948, rather than at the end of 1950, I would never have been persuaded to move to Boston in search of a livelihood. I would have been content to remain in New York and take a job there, if anywhere.

And that would have been bad, I think. My academic position at Boston University School of Medicine was valuable to me; the prestige it brought was useful; the background it supplied for writing other than science fiction was indispensable. No, my literary poverty lasted just exactly long enough. It served to deposit me in the Medical School, and then it rose sharply so that I would not be stranded there for life.

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With all that, I was ready for a hilarious New Year's Eve party and, as the year before, we celebrated at Roz Wylie's house.